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JOKING AND AVOIDANCE, HOSTILITY AND INCEST: AN ESSAY ON GISU MORAL CATEGORIES

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This article discusses joking and avoidance relationships among the Gisu in the context of kinship classifications and behaviour, arguing that these behaviours should be seen as setting the parameters for moral discourse. The basis of the Gisu social order rests with *lukoosi*, a restraint which is sanctified in the person of the mother-in-law who is revered by avoidance. Joking partners, on the other hand, may revile each other with impunity; with them any contact seems possible. The joking relationship is a fixed point in the 'normal' constellation of social relationships, and encodes its own ritualised form of self-abnegation. It is seen to have its origin in a peace pact and the licence which becomes possible rests on the fact that the parties have forsworn vengeance. Mother-in-law avoidance and the joking relationship encode contrasting dramas of renunciation; of love and sexuality in the one instance and of hatred and warfare in the other.

The subject of this article is the meaning of joking and avoidance patterns in an East African society, that of the Gisu of Uganda. I aim to provide a new way of looking at a topic as old as academic anthropology, yet one which still presents itself as a 'puzzle'. Indeed, the very 'oddness' of African joking forms has led to the development of an interpretative literature around them and the critical parameters of kinship structure with which they are often associated. Radcliffe-Brown defined joking relationships in terms of their essential ambivalence. They are a 'peculiar combination of friendliness and antagonism' (1952 [1940]: 91), a play upon enmity, which gives simultaneous expression to the common and divergent interests of parties to an alliance. He saw avoidance relationships as another means of achieving the same end, namely, of managing potentially difficult ties of alliance. The Gisu have both these relationship forms; indeed they might be said to have extreme versions of them. Avoidance between mother-in-law and son-in-law is virtually total, whilst joking between non-kin is marked by an exaggerated element of hostility.

It is not only these relationships that are odd but also the entire system of classificatory kinships. What, we might ask, is the point of all this specification of conduct? Why is appropriate human conduct cut up and distributed among different categories of relative in the way that it is? We might of course accept, with Radcliffe-Brown, that it works to regulate action and to resolve points of tension in the social structure, but to go further we need to enquire into what it is saying about the basic parameters of moral action, about the essential categories of social life and of human possibility.

I follow Schneider's (1968) lead in moving from a 'social' to a more 'cultural' level of analysis, from a dominating concern with 'structure' to one more concerned with

'sentiment'. The move is thus away from seeing classificatory kinship systems as echoing lineage structure and systems of marriage towards a more hermeneutic concern with the polarities of value which they enshrine. In this I must closely follow LeVine (1984), who has argued that behaviours such as mother-in-law avoidance are best seen as setting the parameters for moral discourse and behaviour. Rather than interpreting them as odd quirks of a system of classificatory kinship, they should be regarded as essential for establishing the moral verities it posits. 'Avoidance' as a moral injunction, then, should not be seen as restricted to one or two relationships in any system, to the extreme exemplars, but rather as providing a 'model for conventional moral behaviour' (LeVine 1984: 74) and thus part of a more general moral code. I want to extend this view to argue that these patterns provide not just a template for moral action but an implicit philosophy, a metacommentary on the nature of social life and its possibilities.

I do not therefore ask, as did Radcliffe-Brown, what particular problems are 'solved' by joking or avoidance for the organisation of social relations, nor do I ask, as did Freud, how they promote the psychic adjustment of individuals. Instead, I offer a hermeneutic account of joking and avoidance in Gisu society. What story are these formalised dramas of relationship telling? What, for example, do they tell us of the Gisu conception of relationship and of the problems posed by sexuality and violence?

The argument of the article is divided into three sections. In the first I offer a brief account of the basic principles that inform Gisu kinship classifications and behaviour.¹ I then turn to the joking relationship, *bukulo*, with its hostile forms of interaction. Finally I review some of the literature on joking in order to develop my own interpretation of joking and avoidance patterns.

The structuring of sentiment

The Gisu number some 500,000 and are Bantu-speaking agriculturalists, living on the slopes and foothills of Mount Elgon in eastern Uganda. Although their lineage organisation is patrilineal, the stress on generation as a categorising principle tends to override distinctions in terms of lineality. Relationships are conceived to lie on a scale from familiarity to distance and respect. Familiarity is the privilege of those defined as equal in generational terms, but between proximate generations the relationship is dominated by 'respect', *lukoosi*, and between members of the opposite sex by the added sexual inhibition of *tsisoni*.

Lukoosi has a range of related meanings, all of which are relevant to understanding kinship behaviour. In the first place, *lukoosi* is respect, a respect which embraces not only the proper esteem rendered to persons but also a sense of the proper ordering of things, of customs and tradition. *Lukoosi* in this general sense is the fundamental principle upon which all orderly social relationships and conduct are based. A person 'with *lukoosi*' is thus not only a courteous individual but also respectable, honest and law-abiding. At its most general level, *lukoosi* finds expression in the detailed rules of everyday etiquette. In a slightly more specific sense, *lukoosi* is mandatory among all kin, who must show proper respect for each other by observing due decorum. More specifically still, it is the guiding norm for relationships among people of proximate generations where it carries more forcefully the connotations of distance and formality. The behaviour prescribed between the generations is thus an explicit politeness which must be maintained equally by both sides. Thus a father must respect his son just as his son respects him. The *lukoosi* rules here tend to render formally unequal statuses

egalitarian in everyday practice. Both seniors and juniors address each other, according to sex, as either *papa* (father) or *mayi* (mother).

Tsisoni occurs between the sexes and operates to intensify the restrictions imposed by *lukoosi*. The term can be translated as sexual restraint or shame. In relationships between people of opposite sex and proximate generations, where both *lukoosi* and *tsisoni* obtain, familiarity is severely restricted. Conversely, in relationships between people of the same sex and generation, where neither obtain, familiarity and intimacy become possible and there are no restrictions on physical proximity or touching, or on topics of conversation. However, the more general stipulation of *lukoosi* in relationships of all kinds continues to hold, and poses limitations on the types of behaviour thought suitable. Specifically it rules out any kind of joking or teasing, the only exception to this among consanguines being in the relationship between grandparents and grandchildren.

These rules of etiquette point to the emphasis, throughout the kinship system, on the distinctive and antipathetic interests of proximate generations, and on the corresponding identity of interests among people of the same generation. This is linked to a radical difference in their 'sexuality'. Kinship etiquette marks out two distinctive aspects of kinship linkage: that which might be called generative consanguinity and that of conjugal sexuality. The first, the relationship of parent and child, demands formality and respect and provides the model for all behaviour between people of adjacent generations, who are all seen to stand in relation of begetter to begotten. Moreover, the two generations are seen to 'beget' each other in a continuous cycle: fathers beget sons but these sons in turn will beget children of the same generation as the father. This goes along with the equation of the alternate generations of grandparent and grandchildren.² By contrast the second kind of kinship linkage, based upon conjugal sexuality, colours all relationships *within* the generation, with sisters to some extent being identified with wives. This becomes clear in the rules regulating marriage, the use of bridewealth and attitudes towards sexual offences, all of which operate to identify the different sexual prerogatives of the generations.

For example, the rules which determine the use of bridewealth bind together not only brothers and sisters, with the brother using a portion of his sister's bridewealth to marry himself, but also patrilateral parallel cousins and all cross cousins. These cousins are addressed as 'siblings' and all have rights to a portion of a girl's bridewealth and to inherit each others' widows.³ Proximate generations are clearly opposed in these respects, for while in a single generation marriage and consequent bridewealth redistribution forge close bonds of privilege among its members, who may refer to each other's wives as 'my wife', this is translated into restriction and restraint between the generations. As has been seen, sexual distance is absolute between people of the proximate generation and opposite sex, whether kin or married to kin, all of whom may be referred to as *basoni*.⁴ With them, incest or adultery is regarded as 'polluting', and not just 'bad' because it 'spoils kinship', as is the case with such offences among members of the same generation. Indeed, the collective interest of men of the same generation in each other's wives precludes any compensation being levied for offences such as adultery since it is considered that the woman was paid for by the bridewealth of the generation of kinsmen as a whole. Furthermore, the bridewealth received from the marriage of a woman may not be used for the marriages of men of the proximate generation, nor, in normal circumstances, may such men inherit each other's widows.⁵

Thus, while the junior generation inherits land and other forms of property from the senior generation, the lines which serve to demarcate the divergent interests of the two generations are drawn with respect to sexual roles and prerogatives.

This has special significance for affinal connexions, which appear as exaggerations of those found within the sphere of consanguinity. The simplest way to represent this situation is to concentrate on how, within the latter sphere, the parameters of *lukoosi* and *tsisoni* effectively create four basic types of relationship: those of same sex and generation (B/B, Z/Z); those of same sex, different generation (F/S, M/D); those of different sex, same generation (B/Z); and those of different sex, different generation (F/D, M/S). Affinal relationships may be seen to modify these in two directions: towards greater intimacy and towards greater distance. Thus one can plot relationships according to the degree of *tsisoni* and *lukoosi*, from intimacy to distance, yielding a gradient which in same-sex relationships runs:

WB/ZH - B/B - F/S - WF/DH;

HZ/BW and co-W/co-W - Z/Z - M/D - HM/SW

and in cross-sex relationships runs:

H/W - B/Z - M/S and F/D - WM/DH and HF/SW

In each gradient, relationships among consanguineal kin occupy the middle ground and those with affinal kin are transformations or exaggerations of these relationships.⁶ Thus the lack of formal restraint between brothers becomes the 'mutuality' between brothers-in-law which is seen to be based upon the successive use of the same cattle to marry a wife. They are the prototypical 'friends'. In the same way, the brother/sister relationship transforms into that of husband/wife. One may note here that the sister is clearly seen as proximate to 'wife', not only in so far as her cattle are used by her brother to marry but also because she stands as the symbolic wife in her brother's circumcision ritual.⁷

In the opposite direction, the father/son relationship with its *lukoosi* component transforms into that of father-in-law/son-in-law, with its more formalised norms of respect, and the mother/son relationship, already marked by both *lukoosi* and *tsisoni*, transforms into that between mother-in-law and son-in-law, with its requirement of total distance. This emphasises the fact that the contrasts are most extreme in cross-sex relationships which act to define the limits of the system, with husband/wife standing at the opposite pole to wife's mother/daughter's husband. Sexuality and avoidance could nowhere be more clearly opposed, and the relationship with the mother-in-law can rightly be seen to attest to an almost phobic reaction to incest (understood in the broad sense of the sexually prohibited), as Stephens and D'Andrade (1962) have argued.⁸

The relationships between wife's mother and daughter's husband and between husband's father and son's wife are both characterised as '*bumasala*', whose essential connotation is one of sexual prohibition.⁹ In the case of the father-in-law/daughter-in-law relationship the restrictions are of necessity lightened due to the fact that, with virilocal residence, the two live in close proximity. The relationship with the wife's mother thus stands as the prototype for all relationships in the *bumasala* category. A man's avoidance of his mother-in-law combines both fear and respect. Men say both that they respect and honour their mothers-in-law because women are more fertile than men, and that they are afraid to see them in case they might find them beautiful. Indeed, the prohibitions focus on the fear of sexual contact, of touching or seeing one another naked. However, the notion of *bumasala* extends beyond this to include all

that is obscene. Terms of abuse are referred to as words of *bumasala*, which are thought to have the power to harm irrespective of the relationship between people. Basically, however, *bumasala* refers to what is sexually forbidden and the restrictions entailed are of such cardinal value that breach is felt to be an abomination.

The set of attitudes associated with *bumasala* can be examined further by looking at the connotations of *lukoosi*, *tsisoni* and the word more generally used for shame, *kamanyanyu*. These terms have overlapping sets of association and reference. *Lukoosi*, described earlier, can be glossed in the present context as 'respect'. *Tsisoni*, while it too implies respect, is of a form best rendered as sexual reticence or inhibition. *Tsisoni* 'catches' you when sexual distance is breached. The affect experienced here is likened to that of shame, *kamanyanyu*. Yet shame provides only a partial gloss as it fails to capture both the strength and the range of this affect, which also implies fear. Thus *kamanyanyu* may catch a child when he is scolded, but equally it might catch an adult in a variety of different but dangerous situations. One man gave the following list of things which might inspire *kamanyanyu*: all situations where *tsisoni* is present, walking alone at night or sleeping alone in a house, seeing a snake or a wild animal, walking in a town or seeing a murdered and mutilated body. *Kamanyanyu* seems to apply to raw fear, a sense of the ominous; it is the type of fear which makes your skin crawl.¹⁰ And *tsisoni* is the strongest fear of all. Felt on the skin, if you look directly at your mother-in-law *tsisoni* can catch your body all over. Fittingly perhaps, the punishment, as with most pollution, takes the form of a skin disease.

To return to the kinship context for these attitudes, we may note first that mother-in-law and son-in-law are asymmetric with respect to the basic polarities around which the Gisu have constructed their kinship universe, that is, of sex and generation. And, running through all these classifications is the opposition between conjugal/sexual and generative/consanguineal linkage. Here, the patterned discriminations extend into the most private and intimate sphere of social life. A woman's maternal or procreative role is clearly separated from her conjugal, sexual one, with the intimate physical relationship a woman has with her husband, on the one hand, and her children, on the other, being separated by ritual restrictions (*kimisiro*). Thus if a man becomes seriously ill or incontinent a wife cannot nurse him, for only a woman related as 'mother' can wash and clean his anus and genitals. In a like manner, a man may never touch or suck his wife's breasts for these 'belong to the children' and any injury here is an offence which pollutes the couple and requires ritual annulment and compensation. Thus the Gisu are offered two possible but mutually incompatible models of conduct towards the opposite sex. Following Douglas's (1966) line of argument we may see mother-in-law/son-in-law avoidance as falling at the point of intersection between the two categories; a point which, dramatised by taboo, in turn serves to epitomise the lines of division between them.

Further, a woman's fertility is largely credited to her mother who is said to have 'grown her' and to have protected her from the dangers of sorcery and other misfortune during her childhood. A girl is most vulnerable to malignant supernatural force during her first menstruation and this tends to be specified as the particular charge of the mother, the essential part of any safe rearing. When a girl marries, the debt to her mother is recognised in the gifts of clothes, hoes and other household utensils which she receives; items which fall outside the bridewealth proper and are not repayable on divorce. Yet, in a very real sense, the debt to the mother-in-law can never be repaid.

She has no stake in the exchange of livestock which procure wives for the male members of the family, and Gisu marriage rules ensure that women are not directly reciprocated between families.¹¹

I have set forth the major contrasts which place the behaviour towards the mother-in-law at one end of a spectrum of possible social behaviours. As has been described, the wife's mother/daughter's husband relationship is associated with fear, a fear which hinges on a sexual reticence so strong that it amounts to dread and imposes avoidance. But what then do we make of the joking relationship, *bukulo*, which, as I shall describe, freely makes play with the things of *bumasala*, with the sexually obscene, with violence and hostile abuse?

The joking relationship - bukulo

Bukulo is a hereditary joking relationship which holds between members of different lineages, linking them as joking partners *bakulo* (sing. *umukulo*) to each other. In outline, the pattern conforms to that widely reported in Africa, but differs from those reported elsewhere in that joking partners are neither kin nor affines, nor are they linked by the performance of any mutual service such as in funeral or purificatory rites. Nor do they possess any other role in community or kinship affairs such as that of mediation in disputes. The relationship is thus one which is defined and has meaning solely in terms of the licence given by 'joking', and this licence is explained in terms of the prior hostility between linked lineages. *Bukulo* is thus presented as a peace pact and all its symbolic forms build upon this notion with its dual correlates of amity and enmity.¹²

Gisu joking is extreme and often startling. Joking partners are licensed to revile, abuse and insult each other. Further, it is stressed that *bukulo* exchanges are 'not play' (*xung'aa*) but 'abuse' (*xuxomana*), and thus distinguished from lighthearted jesting or chaffing. In practice the most extreme forms of verbal abuse tend to occur only between those men who are contemporaries and partners (see below) and, in my experience, interactions are more restrained between those of opposite sex. However, in principle, such restraints may be set aside and any type of abuse is licensed.

Abuse may run from relatively innocuous remarks over personal appearance ('big head', 'shrivelled body', 'unkempt hair' and the like) to more direct accusations of witchcraft and the types of animal and sexual obscenities which would in other circumstances undoubtedly precipitate fighting. Indeed, all rude personal remarks tend to carry the implication of witchcraft since they play upon the kind of objectionable characteristics which can be taken as the mark of a witch. If witchcraft is imputed to the recipient of the abuse, however, it is equally imputed to the perpetrator since open abuse and the utterance of obscenities are seen as a form of cursing. This is not to say that witchcraft and *bukulo* are identified in any other ways, but simply to emphasise the abnormality of the behaviour; it is beyond the pale.

Added to this, while many such exchanges are taken in apparent good heart and often accompanied by considerable jocularly, they can also be 'played for real'. In such cases, for the unsuspecting observer, they may be indistinguishable from a real conflict. On one occasion, when travelling in an area unknown to both of us, my assistant and I were caught out in this way and I still vividly remember the panic of our reaction when the local man who had offered to act as our guide was suddenly subjected to a stream of vitriolic abuse from a man whose house we were passing. Under this provocation our guide remained silent for a few minutes and then began

to respond with equal vehemence. My assistant, as apprehensive as myself, suggested that we make a run for it before finding ourselves witness to a brawl or worse. As we left, both men were shaking their sticks at each other. Before we had gone further than a hundred yards, however, our guide ran after us and, catching us up, explained that we had no need to fear as his assailant was only his *umukulo*. Reassured, we returned and, with our flight at least having introduced some leavening, the two men concluded their exchanges at the level of badinage.

The scene described above took place between men who were linked as joking partners, that is by a special partnership contracted between individuals on the basis of the *bukulo* relationship between their lineage segments. While it is said that this relationship may be formed between women it is generally contracted between men, either following the final mortuary ceremonies for the father of one of them or after their own circumcisions. The relationship is developed by the reciprocal 'snatching'—known by the special term, *xutubuta*—of each other's property. These thefts begin with small items, such as pots or chickens, and progress to goods of higher value, the aim being to snatch a cow from each other. Such snatching is done strictly by turn, with one man initiating the exchange and then waiting until his partner retaliates by taking an item of equivalent value. The way is then open to snatching items of greater value, and so on, with the taking of cattle effectively ending the cycle of escalation. Any further snatching between the two is then said to begin anew with the taking of chickens. The 'negative reciprocity of abuse', as Richards (1937) called it, is here carried over to the expropriation of property.

This snatching, and the possibility of playing it for real, are important to understanding the particular elaboration of Gisu joking forms. For joking relationships are said to originate from peace pacts, and these were the main way in which feuds and enmities were concluded among neighbouring people in the past. Hatred is re-enacted in the omission of greetings on meeting, in the seriousness of the abuse and in the mock thefts. This symbolic theme is further developed in the rules associated with the snatching. For example, a man cannot snatch from his joking partner until he has provoked the latter into responding in like terms. Apprehensive as to what he might take, those in the partner's homestead usually attempt restraint for once he has successfully 'picked a quarrel', he may strike the object he wants and make off with it. Moreover, when livestock is taken, as is most usual, the animal must be slaughtered on the path on the way home: it cannot be taken alive into the snatcher's home where it could then be used for breeding. *Bukulo* is equated with destruction: with the taking of life and consequent enmity.

Snatching of this kind takes place at yearly or even longer intervals and Christmas has become a favoured time for it. The Gisu see this progressive snatching as a way for the two men to 'test' the strength of their relationship. The toleration of such thefts is seen to strengthen the 'friendship' between the two. Yet this bond is of *bukulo*, and not of friendship (*busaale*), from which it is held to be qualitatively different by virtue of both its enduring nature and the element of hostility. It is said that unlike friendship, *bukulo* cannot die since it does not depend on personal whim or the vagaries of individual affection, but is a relationship which is renewed with the same force in each succeeding generation. Further, the symbolic theme of violence and hostility sharply distinguishes *bukulo* from normal friendship. It is seen to be grounded in bitterness, *cilulu*, a term that carries the connotations of might and potency. The most bitter medicines to taste

are those deemed most efficacious; the bitterest experiences are those which endure the longest. Like kinship, *bukulo* is a perpetual alliance, but its roots are seen to lie in enmity, in past bitterness which can never be forgotten.

Yet, while hatred is said to underlie the particular forms taken by the relationship, the pact equally implies peace and friendship. *Bakulo*, under pain of the destruction of their lines, may not take offence or respond with real antagonism. Nevertheless, hatred is an ever-present facet of the relationship and is said to rise once more to the surface—to be an emotive factor in the situation—at times of illness and death when joking partners are identified once more as ‘killers’. Joking partners do not visit each other during illness for it is said that if they do, the sick person will die. Again like enemies, following a death, they practise total avoidance, neither meeting nor speaking. This is further elaborated in southern areas of Bugisu in beliefs that the ghosts of the *bakulo* ‘snatch’ the shadow soul of the dead person, keeping it until the final mortuary ceremonies are performed. Then, in some areas, the living *bakulo* attend to snatch the tail of the sacrificial ox and the shadow soul is released to join the ghosts of his own kin. This is the only mortuary ceremony attended by *bakulo* and the relationship among the living kinsmen must thereafter be remade and the hatred ‘cut’ once more. Such ceremonies are effective re-enactments of the original compact.

The peace treaty which created *bukulo* was marked by the killing of a dog. This graphically represents the ending of hostilities by symbolically striking at the very motives which provoked them. For the Gisu the dog epitomises anti-social trouble-making, *kamaya*. It has ‘bad blood’, is described as indiscriminate in all its habits and proclivities, whether sexual, aggressive or in eating, and is universally despised. Emphatically, the Gisu do not see the dog as a friend to man but more as the enemy within the camp; the unsocialisable domestic animal inherently opposed to the discipline and conventions of the human social order. It thus represents the disregard for normal conventions which leads to trouble and ill-will within the community, and its outcome, hatred, *cixonde*. The dog is also the only domesticated animal which is not eaten, and this prohibition extends to all animals which fall into the ‘dog’ class, a taxon which includes most of the wild carnivores, leopards and lions. All associations thus reinforce the idea that the dog is a hostile predator which is tolerated within human society for one purpose alone, as a guard animal, where its natural aggressiveness can be used to fend off the danger from human enemies. Dogs are frequently beaten, starved and fed ‘medicines’ in order to make them fiercer. The killing of a dog to cement a peace pact thus forcefully carries the idea of destroying ‘disorder’ and all its associated evils. Once the dog has been killed, the two parties may freely enter each other’s houses, their hatred removed, transformed into a form of friendship, but not forgotten.

Discussion

Radcliffe-Brown’s (1924; 1940; 1949) series of papers on joking relationships in Africa has generated a vast critical literature and dominated the terms of the discourse ever since. His emphasis on their essential ambivalence, combining both friendship and antagonism, goodwill and hostility, has been incorporated into the majority of analyses, even where the authors have been otherwise critical of his approach (for example, Apthorpe 1967; Beidelman 1966; Douglas 1968; Rigby 1968; Sharman 1969). By contrast, some more recent commentaries (Freedman 1977; Howell 1973; Kennedy

1970; Stevens 1978) have argued that we should play down the hostile element and concentrate on the goodwill. I propose to deal with this position first, because I believe that it fails to come to grips with the abusive joking patterns of Africa and also runs against a whole current of thought on the nature of the joke and the comic. Bergson (1911), Freud (1960) and Koestler (1964) have all seen hostility as an essential aspect of the comic. Thus, in dealing with relationships such as the Gisu *bukulo* one can argue that there is no paradox but instead a neat symmetry of form and content.

Of those who have argued that Radcliffe-Brown overstressed the hostile, disjunctive aspects of joking, Howell puts the matter in the most general terms, denying that the 'need to symbolize separation accounts for teasing relationships. On the contrary, in most cases teasing appears to *deny* distance and to symbolize potential closeness' (1973: 4). It flourishes in the 'safe area' of social relationships. Thus, *pace* Radcliffe-Brown, teasing does not act to reduce latent hostility but rather develops only where there is none. Alternative functions are then proposed for joking-cum-teasing: it is said to test and affirm social relationships and boundaries (Howell 1973), to symbolise exclusiveness (Stevens 1978) or to be a marker of special affinal solidarity (Freedman 1977).

This formulation does provide a possible gloss on teasing relationships that are found within the sphere of kinship in Bugisu. The teasing which occurs here is explicitly seen as reflecting real feelings of trust and friendship, and to be incompatible with any actual conflict or tension in the relationship. Reciprocal relationships between brothers-in-law and between men who have married sisters, or between both men and women whose children have married, are seen as ideal foundations for the development of life-long friendships which can, and frequently do, outlast the marriages upon which they are based. These relationships are critical for developing the network of ties a man needs to facilitate the social round, and to provide for mutual support and economic help. Yet, although amicability is built into the terms of such relationships, the onus is upon individuals to cement them over time. It is in this area of social relationships that teasing or jocular banter is considered appropriate.

Yet with joking between affines the normal rules of polite behaviour continue to hold; a man must be careful not to overstep the mark. Occasional banter is allowed rather than enjoined between them. Indeed, in such relationships a man has the right to take offence if he considers himself to be abused unnecessarily. For this reason the expected forms are mild, and make play with the nature of the relationships as, for example, when a man addresses his wife's brother as 'my wife'.¹³ The mutedness of abuse here—as Howell clearly recognises—comes from the fact that joking or teasing is an extremely risky strategy in social interaction and one that is always open to misinterpretation.¹⁴

Further, the interactive strategy employed here is clearly recognised by the participants. For the Gisu, a playful exchange of insults is considered admissible only where there is little possibility of real grievance. These teasing relationships flourish in a relatively narrow sector among kin and affines who are defined as equal yet removed structurally from the lines of direct economic competition. Thus grandparents and grandchildren may tease each other, making play with the ambiguity which relates them both as seniors/juniors and as members of a single generation, but it is not deemed possible (let alone suitable) among siblings because of the likelihood of dissension over the distribution of property. Since all relationships among kin and affines are bound up with the transmission of property through inheritance, bridewealth exchange or

gift, joking among kin is always restricted in scope, and can in no sense be regarded as a strategy for overcoming conflict, whether potential or actual.

On this point I am in full agreement with Howell. For the Gisu, joking among kin is only possible in situations where direct conflict of interests is considered unlikely and, additionally, where the personal relationship is strong enough to 'take it'. Given this overt frame, the degree of licence involved is related to the actual relationship and may be seen to 'mark, test and affirm it', as Howell argues (1973: 3). If, however, joking of this kind only flourishes in the 'safe area of social relationships', it is clearly not the case that the safety of such relationships is given *a priori*. Rather, where such joking occurs it attests to the constructive attempts of individuals to build up amicable relationships. It is a personal achievement. Further, such teasing modes as do occur are a relatively peripheral aspect of relationships which are primarily defined and recognised in other terms.

In all these respects they stand in sharp contrast with joking relationships such as *bukulo*, where the reigning symbolic forms are antagonistic and where no intimacy is expected between the partners. A theory whose key term is familiarity cannot help us to understand such forms. My point is not that different kinds of joking relationship can be distinguished (this has been done elsewhere, see Sharman 1969; Apthorpe 1967; Rigby 1968), nor is it that there are discrete types which must have different explanations (Freedman 1977). We need to recognise a spectrum of different forms, built from a combination of contrasting tendencies and symbolic devices, variously exploited. The theme of friendship accompanied by a play on sexuality and affinal connexion is one (see especially Kuper 1982), the theme of hostility is another. Nevertheless, in recognising this diversity, we should avoid any temptation to construct a taxonomy. Approaches which develop an opposition between the parameters of friendship/conjunction and hostility/disjunction risk leading to just such a position. To my mind this misses exactly what was valuable in Radcliffe-Brown's contribution to the topic, which stressed the mixture of attitudes involved. Here it is important to emphasise, yet again, that in Bugisu even the joking that occurs within the sphere of kinship and affinity takes the form of insults which, however mild, highlight potential aggression.

Indeed from Bergson (1911) and Freud (1960) onwards, just such a mixture of attitudes has been seen to characterise the comic. Thus, while Radcliffe-Brown's coinage of the term 'joking relationship' to cover the aggressive joking forms of Africa has often been regarded as a misnomer, this criticism overlooks the fact that almost any 'joke' contains an element of hostility. Bergson writes that 'comedy can only begin at the point where our neighbour's personality ceases to affect us. It begins, in fact, with what might be called a growing callousness to social life' (1911: 134). The joke, then, depends on an act of distancing, a suppression of sympathy which, in Bergson's view, gives full play to the intelligence, to reason, to exploit the risible absurdities of life. Koestler too, in seeing wit as an essential mode of creativity, argues that it has an aggressive element. Its one indispensable ingredient is 'an impulse, however faint, of aggression or apprehension. It may be manifested in the guise of malice, derision, the veiled cruelty of condescension, or merely as an absence of sympathy with the victim of the joke—a 'momentary anaesthesia of the heart', as Bergson put it' (1964: 52). It is the instinct which turns aside the sword even by using it.

To suggest 'teasing relationship' (Howell 1973) or 'privileged familiarity' (Stevens 1978) as a substitute for the term 'joking relationship' is thus largely to miss the point,

just as it is inadequate to the simple descriptive task of characterising relationships such as the Gisu *bukulo*. As a first step, therefore, we return to Radcliffe-Brown's insight concerning the ambivalence evidenced in joking and to his discussion of the problem in the context of kin classifications and avoidance.

How then might we begin to interpret these relationships? We might start with the idea that kinship of the classificatory kind provides for a structuring of sentiment, allowing affective behaviour to be distributed between different classes of people in different ways. This distribution does not exist in reified abstraction but forms part of people's experience of their social world and its possibilities. Further, joking and avoidance may be looked upon as moral dramas of relationship, dramas which break up the complacency of everyday forms of interaction and, in so doing, open up a window on the possibility of relationship.

Let me return, in summary, to the major themes of Gisu kin classification and etiquette. First, all kinship relationships involve restraint, *lukoosi*. Secondly, this restraint is more stringent between those of adjacent generations, who stand in relationship of 'parents' and 'children', and more marked still between those of opposite sex. Thirdly, this goes along with a rigid distinction between procreative and conjugal roles and the confinement of conjugal sexuality within each generation. Fourthly, affinal relationships are exaggerated versions of consanguineal ones: intimacy is more intimate and respect more compelling. In relationship to a man, a wife thus stands at the opposite extreme to her mother, and brothers-in-law are more 'familiar' than brothers. Brothers-in-law, men whose children have married and men whose wives are sisters may indulge in light jesting with each other, but brothers never. In the opposite direction, the twin constraints of respect and sexual inhibition find their fullest expression in the absolute nature of *bumasala* avoidance between a man and his mother-in-law.

Thus the mother-in-law is the focus for the most stringent restraint, and the relationship in effect epitomises the essence of kinship rules which all involve some form of restraint. By contrast, the joking relationship rides roughshod over the distinctions of kinship and marriage with which it is held incompatible. Furthermore, the joking relationship can be opposed to both 'ends' of the elaborate system of kinship behaviours. Thus to take the brother-in-law relationship as exemplifying the mutuality created by a link of conjugal sexuality, we may note that brothers-in-law, like *bakulo*, cement their relationship over time by increasing the scale of their reciprocities, but whereas brothers-in-law feast one another, *bakulo* engage in negative reciprocity, a sanctioned appropriation of goods which are destroyed or 'eaten' by one side alone. In the case of the mother-in-law, distance is dictated by respect and the asymmetric gift of life, whereas the joking relationship is associated with death and mutual destruction. A triangulated set of contrasts thus emerges: mutual gift of life; debt of life; mutual debt of death. If we add to this set the relationship between those in dispute, we have a set of behavioural options as follows: amity; avoidance motivated by respect; licence; avoidance motivated by enmity.

These manifest oppositions between kinship and non-kinship, restraint and licence, and life and death, may be elaborated still further. Indeed, one of the challenges of interpretation here is precisely the range of themes, contrasts and polarities that it is possible to identify. In addition, both the avoidance and joking relationships involve reversal. In the case of *bumasala*, a marriage in effect transfers a generation of people of the opposite sex from permitted sexual partner to a category which is absolutely

forbidden. In the case of *bukulo*, a fight or war can conclude with a positive transformation of enmity into alliance, conceived in terms of enduring and absolute friendship.

At this point we may return to those analyses of joking, which have taken their cue from Radcliffe-Brown and put the emphasis on ambivalence and the theme of reversal. In so doing they have extended the interpretative framework by exploring the cosmological dimensions of the pattern. Beidelman (1966), for example, considered the problem in terms of transformations, regarding jokers as ambiguous, liminal figures. But if jokers are mediators we have then to pose the question of what they mediate between. What are the relevant boundaries of the social universe? How indeed should the social universe be conceived?

In fairly orthodox terms one can see the social universe in terms of sectors of sociability, the gradual phasing out of moral responsibility with social distance, as Evans-Pritchard (1940) has explained for the Nuer and Sahlins (1972) for 'tribal' societies in general. Kinship at the core may then be contrasted with enmity on the periphery. Thus, we might see both mothers-in-law and joking partners as intercalary figures, points of contact between solidary kin and hostile outsiders. But neither of these polarities is particularly well-developed in Bugisu: kin are neither solidary nor are outsiders necessarily hostile. In part this arises from the fact that the kinship universe is virtually all-encompassing. At the interactive level all are kin, either by consanguinity or by affinity. Parochial marriage patterns and the wide extension of kinship terms ensure that everyone is effectively related, by one tie or another. In any event, everyone is addressed by kinship terms. And, working outwards from the self, relations with distant kin or neighbours with whom only a remote connexion can be traced are characterised by a dilution of kinship conduct. Taboos fade out, incest ceases to become meaningful, obligations dissolve rather than abruptly ceasing. And, at some point along this line, kin become marriageable once more. In fact this is what happens, with Gisu marrying distant kin, and marriage being not so much the way kinship is created as the way it is renewed.

Joking partners alone stand outside this normal schema of sociability. In effect they are the only 'non-kin' in the Gisu social world, the only people not linked by the bonds of sexuality. Thus while one could see joking relationships as existing at the point of divide, mediating between a world of kin and a world of non-kin, this is not altogether convincing. As we have seen the relationship is made, not given. Besides, there is a more interesting line of interpretation. That is, we can also see the social universe in more existential terms, and the relationships of joking and avoidance as representing contrasting tendencies in everyday life. The emphasis is then placed not so much on ambiguity and mediation as on the role of reversals in social life.

Analysing the reversals found in carnivals, Abrahams and Bauman (1978) have written that we should understand these not as literally involving 'the antithesis of behaviour at other times' but as giving expression to the disorder present, if disapproved of, in normal daily life. This is clearly relevant for the Gisu. The neighbourhood is the sphere of the most embittered enmities where conflicts over land, women and breaches of norms are most evident and serious. Avoidance of overt and public strife is an ideal, just as physical avoidance is seen as the main strategy for peaceably dealing with an enemy, allowing time for tempers to cool. This ideal is frequently broken. Thus one could argue that joking gives expression not only to the hostility present at

the edge of the kinship universe, but also to the hostile sentiments present within the community itself.

Like kinship, *bukulo* is a perpetual alliance; unlike kinship it is based on the recognition of violence, on the toleration of the intolerable. To return to the symbolism of dog killing, one could say that *bukulo*, like the dog, represents the invasion of disorder and anarchy into, and its subsequent containment within, the sphere of order and etiquette. This is reminiscent of Douglas's (1968) commentary on the subversive nature of the joke with its juxtaposition of control and non-control. On one level, joking partners represent the reversal of the normal moral order and freely indulge in the forbidden words of *bumasala*, obscenity and insult. Yet, on another level, the very possibility of such reversal points to the essential relativity of human social convention and the creativity of social experience. Pollution can be contained and enmity transformed into friendship; men can not only come to terms with their bitterest experiences but also do so in a way that creates positive social value. In the pool of human experience, the joker, like the trickster, can transform all things, making mockery of the most deeply held canons of propriety and generating value from the apparently valueless.

This, broadly, is Douglas's view. She argues that 'by the path of ritual joking these African cultures too have reached a philosophy of the absurd' and they have done so 'by revealing the arbitrary, provisional nature of the very categories of thought, by lifting their pressure for a moment and suggesting other ways of structuring reality' (1968: 374). In a similar vein, Handelman (1982) argues for the reflexive potentialities of 'play', with its power to take apart the 'clockworks of reality'.

Despite the appealing nature of these formulations, however, I do not see the significance of Gisu joking patterns as lying here. It does not seem to me that these formalised encounters are creative and liberating. In any case, I think the message may well be more straightforward. For if it is possible to regard *bukulo* behaviour as a reversal of normal ideal sociability, it is equally possible to see it as an extreme type of it. We might then see the relationship as representing neither mediation nor reversal, neither liminal nor ludic, but as giving yet another twist to the theme of restraint.

This view raises different interpretative possibilities. For example, if one emphasises reversal, then the joking relationship may be said to give notice of the 'hidden' dimension, the underside of social experience; human nature perhaps set against the repressive forces of the social order. This tends to imply a cathartic model of process; with emotion being channelled and possibly transmuted, as was posited by Radcliffe-Brown's theory. This would also be consistent with a Freudian perspective. Alternatively, if one sees joking as an extreme type of permissible relationship, one end of the spectrum of possibility, then we might say that though it appears as licence, in fact, like other relationships, it embodies its own given mode of restraint. *Bukulo*, as the Gisu say, is a bitter thing.

To expand on this idea, *bukulo* involves the systematic turning of the other cheek. Violence on one side is met with restraint and even generosity on the other, and natural retaliatory impulses are suppressed. A text illustrates this point well.

When they first started *bukulo* my grandfather went to snatch a bunch of bananas in the plantation of his partner. He struck that bunch so that it shattered completely and each banana fell to the ground. Then he went and struck down another bunch. After that he slashed the stem of the trees, felled them and went away. When the owner discovered this damage he asked angrily who had come to spoil his plantation. Neighbours told him that it was his joking partner who had scattered his bananas on the ground. So he went to his joking partner and said 'You have spoilt my bananas but as it is you who

have struck them down then you may eat them'. This act strengthened *bukulo*. Then, on another occasion, he ran to his joking partner's and caught hold of a cow; he hit it, snatched it and killed it. He even ate it but his partner did not pursue him as a thief. And so *bukulo* continued from strength to strength, and it does so in the same way today.

To conclude: I have argued that the structuring of kinship contains an implicit philosophy of being in so far as it patterns experience in terms of the possibilities inherent in social relationships. The basis of the Gisu social order is seen to rest with *lukoosi*, a restraint which is epitomised in the person of the mother-in-law who is revered by avoidance. With her there can be no social contact. *Bakulo*, on the other hand, may revile each other with impunity. With them, all and any contact seems possible. However, rather than either ambiguity or reversal being the main theme, I argue that the keynote is again restraint. The joking relationship may then be seen as a fixed point in the 'normal' constellation of social relationships. The play upon form which Douglas sees as the essence of the 'joke' is here turned back upon itself to constitute a mode of interaction, a class of relationship in its own right. Thus, it is not a fake form but a real form of social interaction. And, like others, it may also be seen to encode its own drama of renunciation, a ritualised form of self-abnegation. Licence is possible only because one has forsworn vengeance. Mother-in-law avoidance and *bukulo* may then be said to encode contrasting dramas of renunciation; of love and sexuality in the one instance and of hatred and warfare in the other; *eros* and *thanatos*.

My argument that it is restraint and denial which are being dramatised in both these relationships calls for a final comment on how far their forms answer to the particular dilemmas of Gisu society. As I have seen it, they objectify the basic 'problem' of order in social life, perhaps in a form which is more akin to a parable than it is to a direct moral lesson. Nevertheless, they stress the importance of restraint, a restraint which is centred upon the self, and which, in the absence of both segmentary loyalties and strong patterns of authority, exists as the only force for consensual social living. The extreme forms that both joking and avoidance take among the Gisu may thus be set against their equally dominant egalitarian ethos. The importance of control gains further force when considering the constituent powers of the personality. In particular the defining power of the male person is seen in terms of a capacity for anger, an anger which leads to hatred and is thus inevitably disruptive of social life. This capacity for anger gives added poignancy to the dilemmas of control, a control which is centred more upon the self than upon others.

NOTES

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¹ For further details, see Heald (1989).

² From this point of view there are only two generations, with adjacent generations reproducing each other while alternate generations replicate each other. Thus physical substance is transmitted between the generations from parents to children while 'life force' is inherited from grandparents to grandchildren. A person is named after the person whose life force he is deemed to have inherited and, most commonly, this is from someone who has recently died in the grandparental generation.

³ The cousins excluded by these arrangements are the mother's sister's children who, significantly, are known as *bamusoni* (sing. *umusoni*) and with whom the relationship approaches avoidance. One of the

worst forms of incest is that with an *umusoni* and the term, from the same root as *tsisoni*, implies the sexually forbidden. Variations of the term are used elsewhere in the kinship terminology. Relatives of the third ascending or descending generation are known by the reciprocal term *cisoni* (pl. *bisoni*). In all cases where these terms are used a magnification of sexual restriction is implied, and possibly an emphatic restatement of a principle. For example, the third ascending and descending generations represent the limits of absolute marriage prohibition since it is usually considered possible to marry those related from the fourth generation. See also note 4.

⁴ *Basoni* is not strictly speaking a kinship term as it is not usually used either in address or reference. Its usage rather is descriptive. Such relatives alternatively may be described as *baxwe*, derived from the root, *xwa*, to marry, through the exchange of bridewealth, *buxwe*. Again, this carries the connotation of sexual prohibition.

⁵ In rare cases a man may inherit a widow from the senior generation, but only in the event that he was already adult at the time of the initial marriage so that she can never have acted as a 'mother' to him.

⁶ This series does not include all kinship relationships, but one can note that in the Gisu system, the relationship with the mother's brother, although terminologically distinct, is akin to that with the father with whom he is closely identified as his 'brother-in-law' and man of the senior generation. The relationship is one of restraint. Likewise, the relationship with the father's sister is likened to that with the mother.

⁷ The relationship between brothers and sisters is characterised by affection and their equality is often marked by the use of the term *yaya*, 'comrade', to address each other. For a man to address his wife as 'sister' is a mark both of esteem and affection.

⁸ Stephens and D'Andrade (1962) have also noted a strong empirical association of extreme kin avoidance with licentious joking patterns, to the extent of suggesting that the world may be divided up between 'avoiding' and 'non-avoiding' societies. Their hypothesis that such avoidances represent a phobic reaction to incest motivated by Oedipal conflicts is consistent with the interpretation of mother-in-law avoidance later advanced in this article. This line of causality, however, runs against the emphasis here on the symbolic construction of the kinship universe in terms of a patterning of permissible behaviours. Indeed, as they admit, while the postulate of Oedipal conflict might 'explain' mother-in-law avoidance in terms of a displacement of desire, it fails to account for the joking relationship or, indeed, for the association between the two forms.

⁹ *Bamasala* has more limited reference than the other terms (*basoni* and *baxwe*) used of people of the opposite sex and generation. It is used only of WM/DH and HF/SW, though, since it includes all relatives in these categories (e.g. all women whom the wife addresses as 'mother') of oneself and close relatives, it is in fact subject to wide extension. It derives from the root, *sala*, to give birth or beget.

¹⁰ Parkin (1986) has contrasted 'raw fear' of this kind with 'respectful fear', with the latter seen as an instrument of hierarchy and calculable in its consequences in a way that the former is not.

¹¹ Gisu marriage rules permit only a one-way flow of women. A marriage may thus initiate a series of marriages in the same direction but there can be no sister exchange nor any other form of exchange-marriage.

¹² I have discussed elsewhere (Heald 1989) this theme of peace-making in the context of East African societies, where the idea that 'joking relationships' originate from a prior state of hostility is widespread. The Gisu present the greatest elaboration upon this symbolic theme and the evidence points to the fact that it was the main mechanism for finishing feuds among neighbouring lineages in the past. The structural context for this unique form of peace-pact appears to be that of small, relatively weak kinship groups living in close proximity and linked by marriage and matrifiliation. See also Tew (1953).

¹³ Kuper (1982) has developed a sophisticated interpretation of this kind of joking among affines, relating its forms to bridewealth exchanges among the peoples of southern Africa.

¹⁴ Thus, as Howell (1973) puts it, the 'exercise and acceptance of licence' may be used to mark and test a relationship, but the element of risk makes it inappropriate in really close, intimate relationships. Yet, the absence of teasing forms here poses evident problems for Howell's thesis with its emphasis on solidarity, a problem which he solves by proposing that it is potential intimacy, a 'willingness to be close' which is symbolised. Potential closeness, however, seems predicated upon the fact of separation, leading one to conclude that if the thrust of Howell's argument runs counter to that of Radcliffe-Brown, the substance remains somewhat unchanged.

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Plaisanterie et esquivé, hostilité et inceste

Résumé

Cet article discute des parentés à plaisanterie et à esquivé parmi les Gisuus dans le contexte des classifications de parenté et des conduites, argumentant que ces conduites devraient être considérées comme établissant des paramètres pour le discours moral. La base de l'ordre social des Gisuus repose sur le *lukoosi*, une retenue qui est sanctifiée dans la personne de la belle-mère qui est vénérée par esquivé. Des partenaires de plaisanterie d'autre part peuvent s'insulter avec impunité; avec eux tout contact semble possible. La parenté à plaisanterie est un point figé dans la constellation 'normale' des relations sociales et code sa propre forme ritualisée d'abnégation. Elle est vue comme ayant ses origines dans un pacte de paix, et l'autorisation qui devient possible repose sur le fait que les parties ont renoncé à la vengeance. L'esquivé de la belle-mère et la parenté à plaisanterie codent des drames contrastants de renonciation; d'amour et de sexualité d'un côté et de haine et de guerre de l'autre.